BOOK REVIEW

Reviewed by Wendy R. Boswell

Thomas P. Bechet. Strategic Staffing: A Practical Toolkit for Workforce Planning. New York, AMACOM, 2002, 377 pages.

Strategic Staffing provides a practical guide and various tools for HR professionals looking to take a more strategic approach to their workforce planning. This book would likely be most useful for HRM professionals in companies currently practicing just-in-time, reactive hiring or for those who have reached roadblocks in their attempt to be more "strategic" in their staffing processes. In other words, while this book provides a thorough discussion of the *why* of strategic staffing, including practical approaches and helpful hints, the information is fairly basic and likely to be of minimal use for companies that currently incorporate workforce planning into their staffing processes.

The book is divided into four sections: Setting the Context, Developing the Strategic Staffing Process, Implementing and Supporting Your Strategic Staffing Process, and Beyond Staffing Plans. There are also appendixes for Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ), Strategic Staffing Templates, and Suggested Overheads as well as a glossary of relevant terms.

The first section of the book provides a basic foundation for the remaining chapters. While it is helpful to introduce the topic and the basic thesis of the book, a great deal of page space is dedicated to telling readers what they will learn in subsequent chapters. This first section does provide practical suggestions such as to link staffing to an organization's strategic planning process, to focus strategic staffing on critical jobs, and to recognize that one size will not fit all units when it comes to staffing plans. However, much of this information is fairly elementary and could have been discussed more succinctly. In fact, the key points of this first section can be found by simply reading the summary section of each chapter. While the more substantive information in this book truly does not begin until section two, there

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is one discussion in this first section worth noting. The author emphasizes the importance of "planning and acting, not just reporting". HR generally and the staffing function in particular are susceptible to collecting and reporting data with little regard to why that data is collected—to solve problems. This is a particular concern with traditional approaches to HR planning. As noted by the author, managers should be provided with *information* and not just *data*. HR professionals must be careful that strategic staffing does not simply turn into a profusion of statistics and reports with little relevance. Even if data are informative, an overabundance is sure to frustrate most line managers. Though it took quite a few pages to get there, an imperative to the strategic staffing process is stated very well by the author: "The best deliverable of the strategic staffing process isn't a tool or model—it is a solution to a staffing problem." How to provide this solution is the question that the remaining sections attempt to address.

As noted, the substance of the book really begins in the second section (Chapters 4–8). Chapters 5 and 6 discuss various techniques for defining staffing requirements under conditions of certainty (e.g., regression, staffing ratios, and staffing profiles) and uncertainty (e.g., scenario planning and "what if" plans) respectively. The author provides helpful examples for each of these techniques. Chapter 7 continues with a comprehensive example of the complete strategic staffing process. The reader can follow along using the CD-ROM provided with the book. The section ends with two case studies and additional examples (Chapter 8). I was fairly disappointed with the case studies presented. They lacked detail and were not clearly aligned with the material discussed in the preceding chapters. The "shorter, less detailed summaries" were particularly vague. The purpose of these summaries seems to be to demonstrate that various companies have implemented strategic staffing processes and these processes were helpful. Yet the reader is left with little applicable information.

One important point made clear in this second section of the book is that a strategic staffing approach is possible for any organization, even if the data are somewhat incomplete or the environment is uncertain or volatile. However, as I read through the chapters in the section, I found myself wondering how strategic staffing as discussed in this book differs from HR/workforce planning discussed in most every basic HRM textbook. The difference appears to be that the former has a longer-term focus than the latter. Again, for the HR professional practicing just-in-time hiring with little, if any, attention to systematic workforce planning, or for those companies that have abandoned strategic efforts fearing it was infeasible given uncertain circumstances, the information provided in this section (particularly Chapters 5–6) should be useful.

The third section of the book is focused on issues around implementation and support. Though most of the information is again fairly general, there are quite a few important issues addressed. For example, the author provides a compelling argument as to why a targeted yet complete approach that has a narrow scope and high impact is likely best for implementing strategic staffing. The importance of line manager involvement is also stressed. Chapter 12 in particular provides a thorough discussion of the role of line managers, including why and how line managers should be responsible for much of the strategic staffing process as well as why and how HRM should act as internal consultant. This is not only an important issue for the staffing function but for HRM generally. In fact, as the author notes, much of the discussion in this third section could be applied to any aspect of HRM. For example, the author stresses that the HRM professional should have a full understanding of the business, should tailor processes and programs to specific needs (one size does not likely fit all within a company), should show an impact, and should integrate HR functions. This latter point is particularly interesting because it suggests that a seemingly staffing issue may actually be a training or compensation issue or at least have implications for these functions. As argued in the strategic HRM literature, a more strategic approach thus involves integrating within HRM as well as across to other business processes.

The third section of this book also provides some basic tools for implementing and supporting strategic staffing. Specifically, a guide for interviewing line managers and others with planning information includes specific questions as well as how to structure an interview. General information on website design is provided in Chapter 13.

The final main section of this book addresses measurement issues. Commendably, the author argues for coupling efficiency measures (e.g., time, cost) with effectiveness measures (e.g., quality). In Chapter 15, the discussion on how to calculate and analyze costs is particular. Unfortunately, the discussion of how to measure effectiveness is rather vague. The author simply states that staffing processes are most effective when critical staffing gaps and surpluses are filled with the right number of people with the right skills and experience (p. 233). Yet, there is no discussion of what this would actually look like. An example would perhaps be helpful. In fact, the measurement section of this book was particularly weak; of course, there are other books focused specifically on measurement issues and calculating various metrics that could be used as supplement.

The final chapter provides a discussion of downsizing and the role of strategic staffing in the process. This is a particularly timely issue as many organizations are confronted with the possibility of mass reductions in their workforce. The chapter discusses how strategic staffing may help an organization avoid common downsizing mistakes. Specifically, strategic staffing will promote consideration of *future* required skills when identifying individuals to let go, reduction efforts where it will least affect future viability (i.e., strategic impact) rather than across-the-board cuts, and more realistic (in terms of cost and sustainability) staffing reductions.

Perhaps the greatest value in this book comes in the supporting material. Specifically, the presentation tools, analysis templates, and even the FAQ are likely to be particularly helpful to HRM professionals looking to make a more strategic impact with their staffing function. As the author notes, the spreadsheets provided on the CD-ROM will have to be modified to address a specific company's needs, yet they provide good templates from which to build.

In sum, while I found the information contained in this book accurate and indeed important, it is likely to be of greatest use for those organizations just beginning to take a more strategic approach to staffing. The more seasoned staffing professional in this area may find some of the tools and helpful hints useful, yet he or she is likely to see this book as too general or elementary.

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